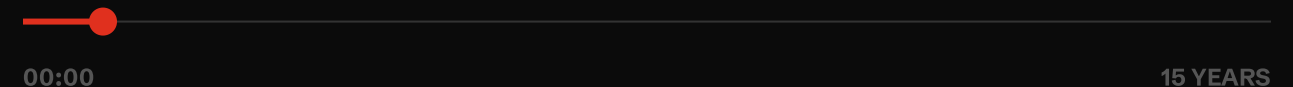


Fifteen years. One platform. Seen from nearly every side.

MATTHEW BATCHELDOR

From platform to creator economy: what I experienced, learned and built across the commercial YouTube ecosystem, and where I believe it is going.



PROLOGUE

I first encountered YouTube as a platform being commercialised.

Years later I was helping build an audience on it, working directly with creators, developing original IP, testing how Shorts and long-form work together, and exploring how AI might improve the decisions behind creator growth.

The platform changed.
So did my perspective.

That is the story. Not a list of jobs, but a widening point of view.

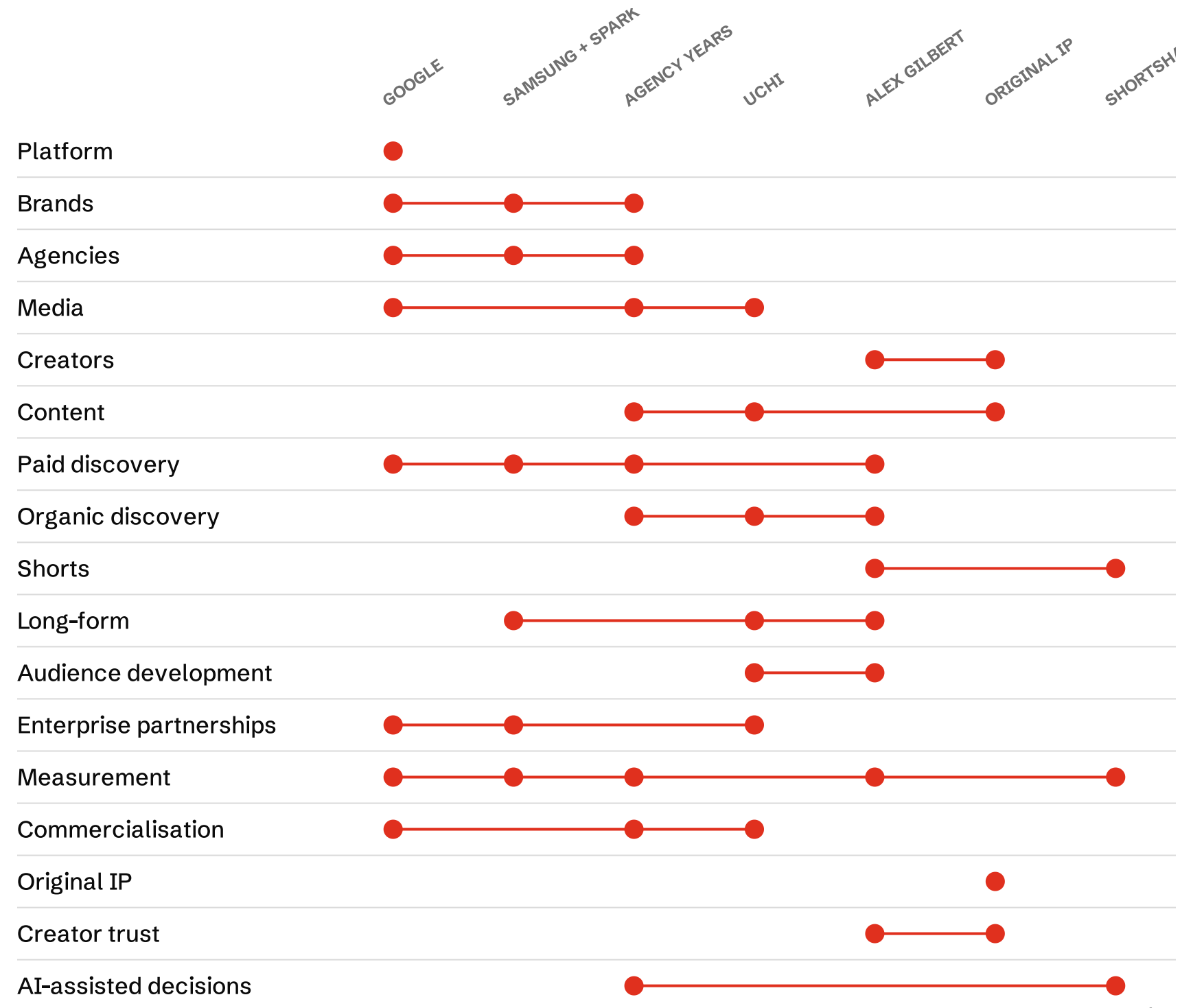


THE REVEAL

Very few people arrive at the creator economy through all of these doors.

Read down any column and you see a job. Read across any row and you see something more useful: the same part of the YouTube value chain, met again from a different side of the table.

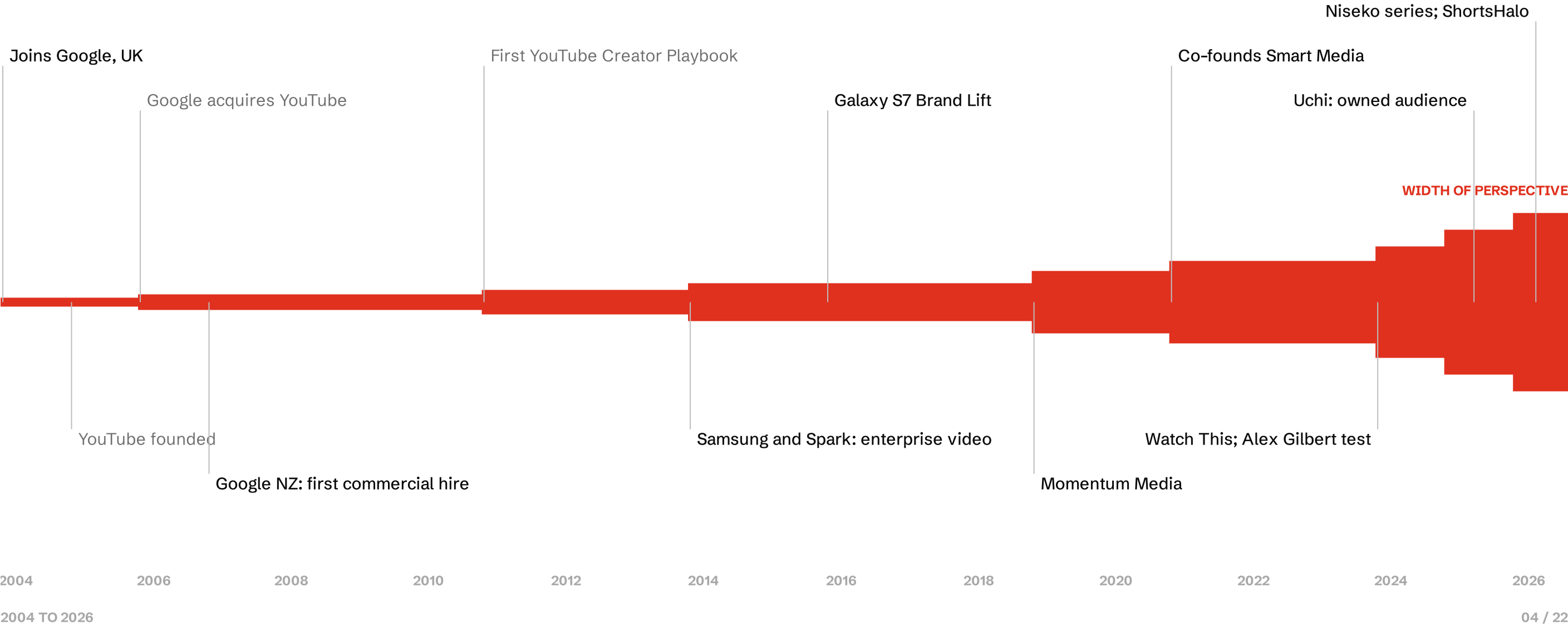
The claim is not depth in every row. It is knowing how the rows connect.



HIDING IN PLAIN SIGHT

The perspective kept widening.

GREY LABELS: YOUTUBE'S OWN MILESTONES



ACT I / INSIDE THE PLATFORM

I didn't discover YouTube during the creator boom. I watched it become a business.

At Google, in the UK and then New Zealand, I worked with major advertisers and their agencies as online video moved from experimental digital inventory to a serious part of brand and commercial strategy. The work was never "selling YouTube". It was helping marketers decide whether video deserved real budget, and proving it when it did.

PLATFORM

TrueView, Masthead, Brand Channels

PROOF

Brand Lift, video effectiveness studies

PARTNERS

Enterprise brands and the major holding groups



Period artefacts. Left: YouTube Brand Channels one-sheet, c.2012, when the pitch to brands opened with "105 million unique users" a month. Right: YouTube Creator Playbook, Version 4, 2013. The first edition appeared in July 2011. Shown for context, not as my work.

ACT I / EVIDENCE / SAMSUNG NEW ZEALAND, 2016

A two-minute film, a live scorecard, and the question every brand asks: **did anyone remember it?**

Samsung, Colenso BBDO, Starcom and Google worked from one shared set of data. Skippable TrueView let us test ad length in market. A Brand Lift study measured what the target audience actually recalled, and near real-time view-through data shaped every later flight.

"We worked with our media partners led by Matt Batcheldor, Google Industry Lead and Starcom Worldwide, on optimisation for the campaign."

MIKE CORNWELL, DIRECTOR OF MARKETING, SAMSUNG NEW ZEALAND. THINK WITH GOOGLE, JANUARY 2017

The Samsung and Starcom video effectiveness work, comparing YouTube and Facebook video views, received a Google Industry Gold Award in January 2016. My role: co-developing the comparison.

+24%

AD RECALL LIFT

77%

OF THE FILM WATCHED, ON AVERAGE

3.4x

COST EFFICIENCY PER COMPLETED VIEW

500K

VIEWS IN UNDER TWO MONTHS

ACT I / PARTNERSHIPS

The biggest YouTube deals were never really media deals.

For Spark, the New Zealand telco, I signed and owned a 12-month YouTube Masthead agreement: 60 homepage days committed quarter by quarter, coordinated across Spark, its creative agency and YouTube's own teams. It was won through education workshops with Spark, its media agency and Colenso BBDO, not a rate card.

That is the pattern I took from Google. Big video commitments happen when brand, agency and platform share a view of what success looks like.

60 homepage days
over 12 months



Reuben Halper (left) with Matthew Batchelor.

WITNESS 1 OF 2

Reuben Halper, Head of YouTube in New Zealand, worked closely with me for nearly a decade.

His written recommendation points to three things: ambitious long-term growth plans, measurable "north stars", and value created across client, agency and Google together, built on CXO and agency relationships. Paraphrased from his written LinkedIn recommendation.

ACT II / SEEING THE OTHER SIDE

After Google, the questions changed.

From 2019 I worked from the agency, operator and content side. Selling a platform is one skill. Being accountable for what a client's money, creative and distribution actually achieve is another.

2019 TO 2020	Momentum Media. Strategy Director: media, digital and audience strategy, client acquisition, measurement.
2021 TO 2023	Smart Media. Co-founder and Managing Partner: creative, paid and organic, YouTube, Meta, data, automation. A 15-specialist team.
2024 TO 2025	Watch This. GM Operations at a social creative agency built on Meta and TikTok. I introduced YouTube into the business.

- 01How do brands really allocate media?
- 02How do creative and distribution work together?
- 03How do paid and organic interact?
- 04How does social video behave across YouTube, Meta and TikTok?
- 05Where does an agency create value?
- 06How do you measure it, honestly?
- 07When does content become commercially useful?

ACT III / FROM BUYING ATTENTION TO BUILDING AN AUDIENCE

At Google I helped companies understand and invest in audiences.

At Uchi I helped build one.

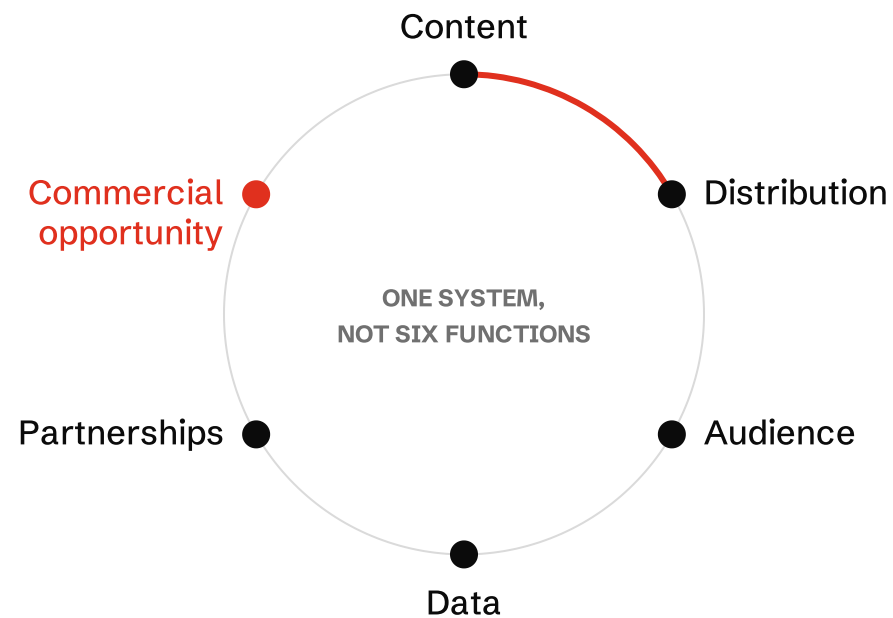
ACT III / UCHI, PARTNERSHIPS DIRECTOR

The numbers are the output. The operating system is the story.

Uchi is a property platform focused on Japan. Its YouTube channel became one of the company's most valuable audience assets. That was a team effort: I helped bring the specialists together, connect the work to commercial goals, and lead across production, channel development, acquisition and retention.

117,000+ **700+** **6.7M+**
SUBSCRIBERS VIDEOS VIEWS

Channel totals during my period with Uchi. Not a claim of personal authorship.



INDEPENDENT VOICES

"Matthew thinks in systems rather than silos."

CHRIS PICKERING, FOUNDER AND CEO, UCHI

"Matthew also played a central role in building our YouTube presence from the ground up, helping lead the team across creative production, channel development, audience acquisition and retention."

CHRIS PICKERING, AUGUST 2026

"Matt was one of the first people to recognise that original video content could become a serious engine for Uchi's growth."

DAMIEN SUNG, EXECUTIVE PRODUCER

POINT OF VIEW

YouTube is no longer a video destination. It is an audience system.

It is the one platform that now spans short, long, live and audio, on the phone in your hand and the television across the room. The interesting question is not what each format is. It is what each format does for the relationship with a viewer, and how they work together.

SHORTS

Discovery

LONG-FORM

Depth

LIVE

Participation

PODCASTS

Habit and intimacy

CONNECTED TV

Lean-back attention

MOBILE

DESKTOP

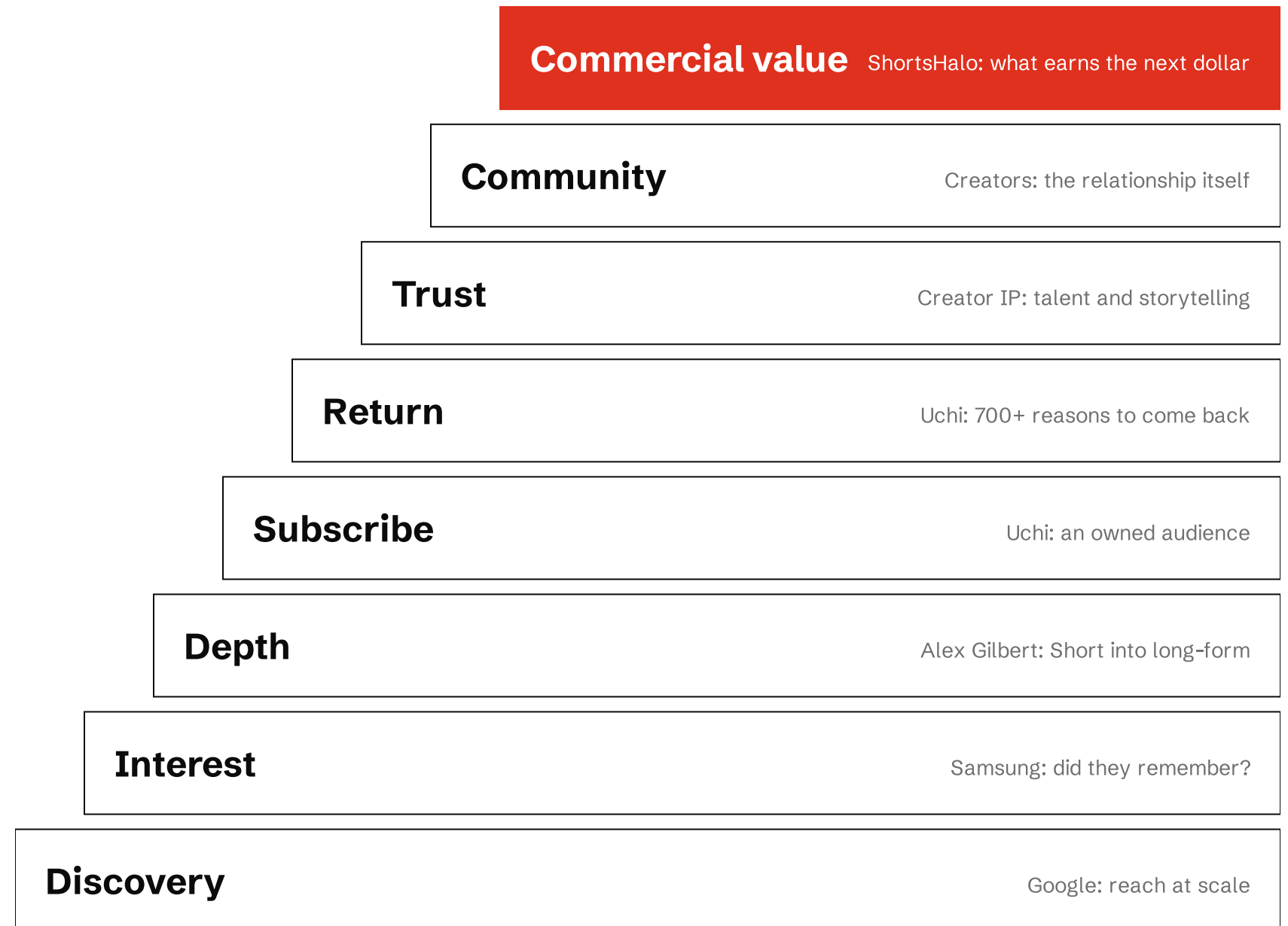
CONNECTED TV

EVERY CONTEXT

THE IDEA UNDERNEATH

Discovery is not the same as audience.

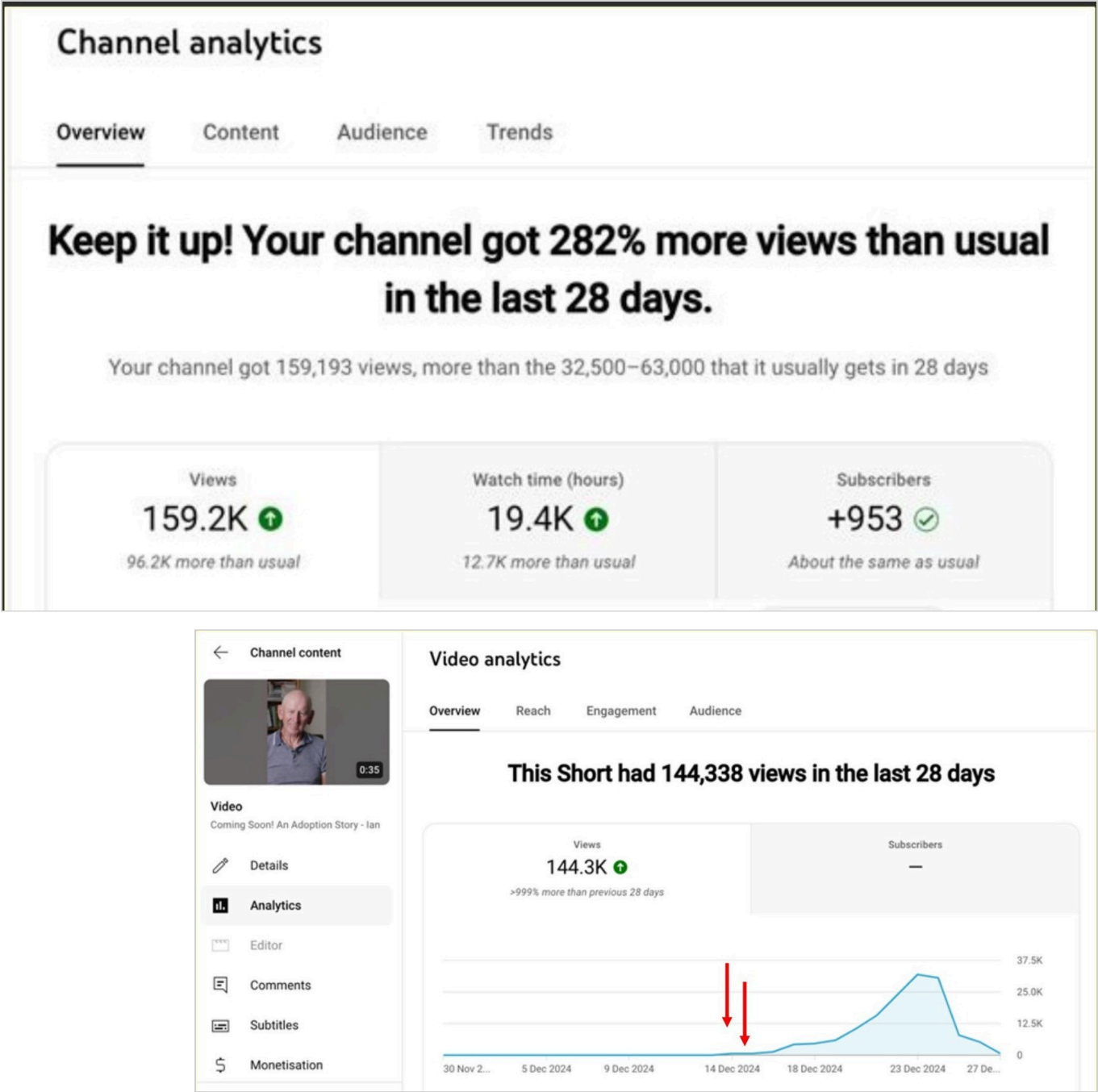
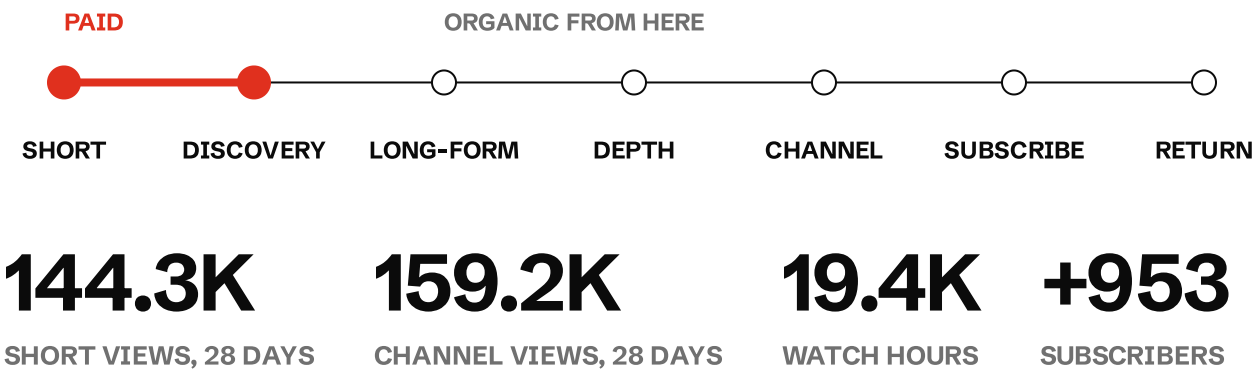
Someone seeing a video once is a view. An audience is what happens when that view turns into depth, return visits and trust. Almost every chapter of my career taught me a different rung of this ladder.



ACT IV / THE CREATOR / DECEMBER 2024

Can a Short work as a discovery layer into a deeper creator ecosystem?

Alex Gilbert's channel, An Adoption Story, sits down with adoptees to explore identity and family. I personally funded a test: promote one Short introducing Ian Manson's long-form story to adoption and charitable audiences, then watch the whole channel, not just the ad.



Source: YouTube Studio Analytics, An Adoption Story channel, 28 days from the campaign launch.

ACT IV / EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE

I wanted to understand what happened, not manufacture a case study.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

Paid promotion clearly drove initial discovery. "YouTube Promoted" traffic delivered nearly nine times the views of the next-best traffic term, and the Short and the long-form story became the channel's top-performing pair.

WHAT WE OBSERVED

Channel views ran 282% above the usual range, and watch time rose 12.7K hours above normal. The creator saw the lift across his wider catalogue.

WHAT WE CANNOT CLAIM

The wider organic effect was not experimentally isolated. And YouTube itself classed the +953 subscribers as "about the same as usual". The case rests on views and watch time, not on subscribers.



"I saw a massive ripple effect across all my top performing videos, reaching over 10,000 views every few days throughout my channel."

WITNESS 1 OF 2 / ALEX GILBERT, YOUTUBE CREATOR, AN ADOPTION STORY



"The use of both Shorts and long-form video, from both a paid and organic perspective, showcases how the new breed of creators can drive real success on YouTube."

WITNESS 2 OF 2 / REUBEN HALPER, HEAD OF YOUTUBE AU/NZ

CREATOR CONTROL + AUDIENCE TRUST

Creator control
+ Audience trust
+ Commercial alignment
= Sustainable value

A creator is not another ad unit. Their value comes from a relationship with an audience, and that relationship rests on the creator owning the format, the length and the final cut. If commercialisation erodes authenticity, it erodes the asset it was meant to monetise.

This is where my enterprise background and my creator work meet.

THE WEAKER QUESTION

How do we monetise this audience?

THE EXECUTIVE QUESTION

How do we create commercial value without destroying the trust that created the value?

ACT V / ORIGINAL CREATOR-LED IP

Some of the best evidence can't be shown yet.

At Uchi I originated an original creator-led YouTube series. It is unreleased, so the premise and the talent stay confidential until launch. What I can share is the shape of the work, and why it is different from the Alex Gilbert case.

ALEX GILBERT SHOWS

Creator growth and measurement

THIS SERIES SHOWS

Creator collaboration and original IP

"Working together as strategic partners, we've bridged high-level commercial strategy with hands-on creative execution, most recently collaborating in Japan to film a new YouTube series set to launch at the end of the year."

DAMIEN SUNG, EXECUTIVE PRODUCER

PRODUCTION FILE

CONFIDENTIAL UNTIL LAUNCH

SERIES TITLE

[REDACTED]

ON-CAMERA TALENT

[REDACTED]

PREMISE

[REDACTED]

LOCATION

Niseko, Hokkaido, Japan

LAUNCH

Winter 2026/27

ORIGINATED BY

Matthew Batcheldor

DEVELOPED WITH

Uchi's Founder and CEO

EXECUTIVE PRODUCER

Damien Sung

MY ROLE

Proposition, talent, development, scripting

DESIGNED AROUND

EDITORIAL DIFFERENTIATION

CREATOR

AUDIENCE

ORIGINAL IP

COMMERCIAL OPPORTUNITY

ACT VI / CREATOR BUSINESS MODELS

Not "how do we grow a channel?" but **how could creator IP become a repeatable, aligned business?**

01	+ 02	+ 03	+ 04	+ 05	+ 06
Existing talent	Under-used IP	YouTube-native packaging	Audience acquisition	Owned audience	Performance-aligned economics

Established presenters and production companies often hold years of archive, and draw large audiences on other people's channels while their own stays small. I have been developing a performance-aligned model for this: YouTube-native packaging of existing IP, audience acquisition into an owned channel, and fees tied to the channel's growth.

The design principle is alignment. If the adviser only wins when the talent's own audience grows, the incentives point the same way, and the strongest argument to talent becomes control rather than money. It remains an exploratory model; specific talent and proposals are private.

ACT VII / MEASUREMENT

One question has followed me through every chapter: **what evidence should change the next decision?**



ACT VIII / AI

After years of making media, audience and commercial decisions, I am exploring how AI can improve the quality of those decisions.

ShortsHalo grew directly out of the Alex Gilbert test. The campaign supplied the questions, not training or validation data. It is an exploratory, AI-assisted decision-support concept: a way to make assumptions, scenarios, signals and thresholds explicit before the next dollar is spent.

NOT A COMMERCIAL PRODUCT. NOT A MODEL OF YOUTUBE'S ALGORITHM. NOT A PRODUCTION RECOMMENDATION SYSTEM.

AI-assisted decision system

Which assumptions, scenarios, signals and thresholds should inform the next decision?

Experiment

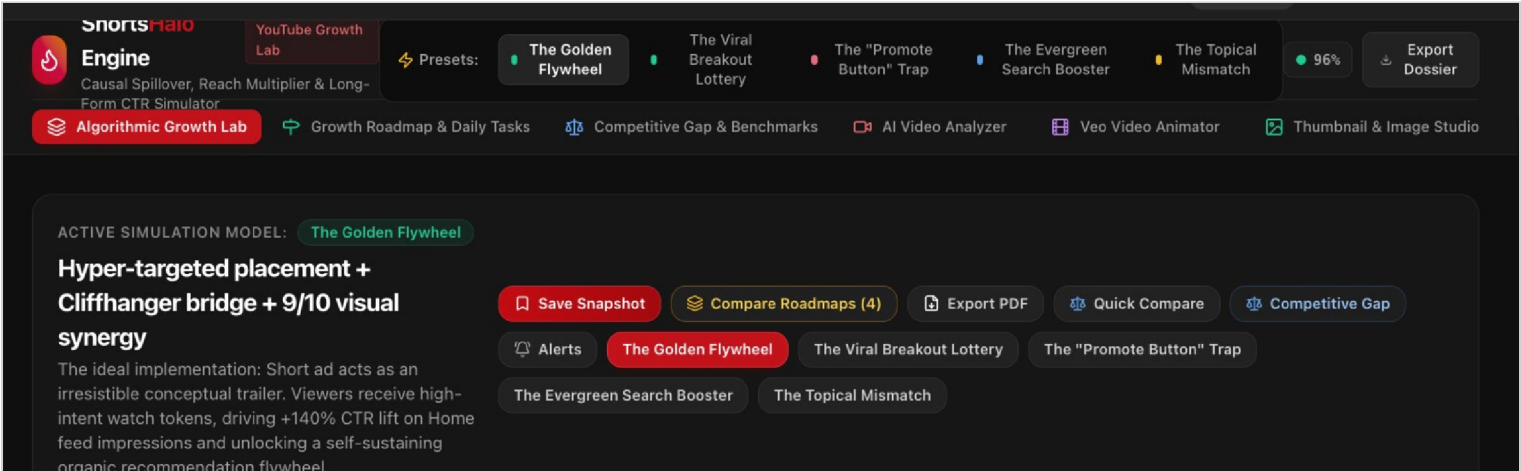
What should we test?

Analysis

Why might it have happened?

Dashboard

What happened?



ShortsHalo prototype interface, built with Google AI Studio and Gemini. Figures on screen are simulated scenarios, not campaign results.

THE PROPOSITION

I am not every specialist in this ecosystem. I have learned how to connect them.

The thread that started as a straight line, platform to brand to agency, has become a network. The executive skill in the middle of it is orchestration.

Understanding every party's incentives

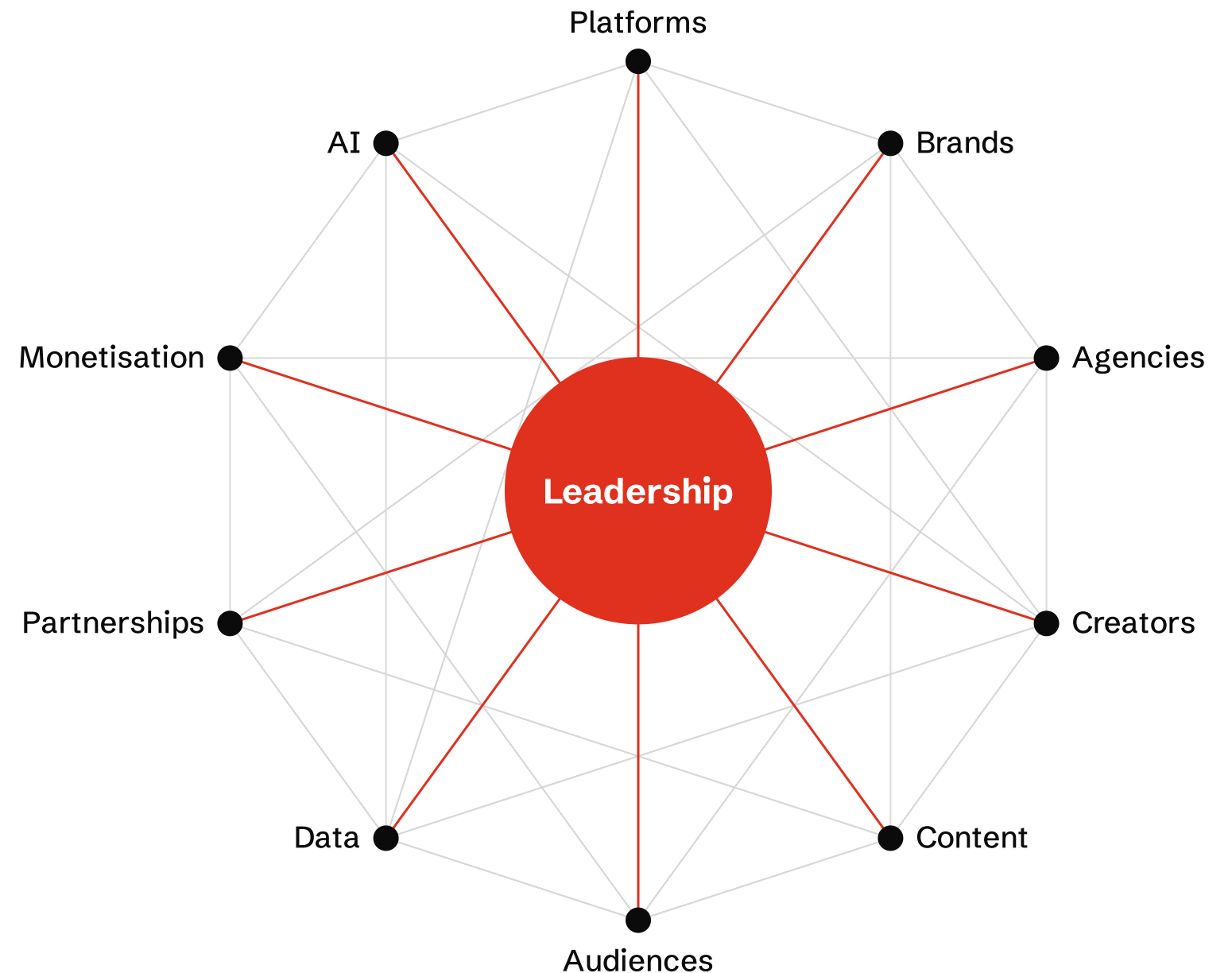
Connecting specialists around one outcome

Recognising the opportunity early

Building partnerships that last

Turning audience into sustainable commercial value

Letting evidence decide the next move



The next chapter of the creator economy will not be won by content alone.

IT WILL BE BUILT AT THE INTERSECTION OF

Creator trust. Audience behaviour. Platform technology. Measurement. Commercial partnerships. **AI.**

I have spent my career learning how those systems connect.
That is the work I want to continue.

MATTHEW BATCHELDOR

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linkedin.com/in/mattbatcheldor
mattbatcheldor.github.io/career-portfolio

NOTES ON EVIDENCE

Credibility is part of the design.

Every figure in this case study comes from a primary source. Where a result is observational rather than proven, it is labelled that way. Confidential work is described by role and structure only.

GOOGLE AND YOUTUBE

Roles and dates: Google UK from April 2004; Google New Zealand to October 2018. Spark Masthead terms from the agreement. YouTube Brand Channels one-sheet and Creator Playbook v4 are public YouTube materials of the period, shown for context.

UCHI

Subscriber and view totals as stated in Chris Pickering's LinkedIn recommendation (August 2026). Video count from the channel page. Figures describe the channel, built by a team.

QUOTATIONS

Chris Pickering and Damien Sung: public LinkedIn recommendations. Reuben Halper: public case-study quote, and a paraphrase of his written recommendation. Alex Gilbert: written testimonial. No private conversations are quoted.

SAMSUNG GALAXY S7

Think with Google APAC, "Samsung's Mike Cornwell on How the Brand Made a Splash on YouTube", January 2017. Ad recall, view-through, cost efficiency and view figures as published there.

ALEX GILBERT

YouTube Studio Analytics for An Adoption Story, 28-day window from the December 2024 campaign. Wider channel effects observed, not experimentally isolated.

CONFIDENTIAL WORK

The unreleased Uchi series and the talent archive model are described without premise, talent or proposal details. ShortsHalo is an exploratory prototype; interface figures are simulated.